4.2 The Gold Rush

A fever of sorts broke out in the late 1840s. Victims from all around the world quit their jobs, left their families, and set off on long, dangerous journeys. The "illness" they suffered from? Gold fever.

MAIN IDEA The discovery of gold in California in 1848 led to a boom in population and wealth.

EUREKA!

By the late 1840s, Sutter's Fort had become a thriving farm community. Various new projects were underway, including the construction of a sawmill upstream on the American River. You might recall from the American Story in this chapter that this was where workers spotted a few flecks of gold on January 24, 1848. Sutter swore the workers to secrecy, but the word soon got out. The next few years would be chaos for Sutter. His men immediately stopped working, abandoned the colony, and went hunting for gold instead.

At first, **prospectors**, or people in search of valuable resources in the earth, found a wealth of gold deposits that were easy to access. They struck gold by digging into hills or mountainsides, or by panning in rivers or streams. Panning involves using a shallow pan to scoop up gravel from the bed of a stream, dipping the pan in the stream to collect some water, and swishing the water around to wash away dirt, clay, and silt. Heavier materials, including particles of gold, remain in the pan.

When prospectors struck gold, they yelled "Eureka!" *Eureka* is an ancient Greek word that means "I have found it." During the California gold rush, shouts of "Eureka!" expressed the thrill and excitement accompanying the discovery of riches. The word was so closely associated with the gold rush that it would become the California state motto.

News of the gold discovery spread to the East Coast and then around the world. Thousands of people bitten by the "gold bug" began heading west to strike it rich.



CRITICAL VIEWING In 1858, George W. Northrup posed as a prospector for a photo to send home to his family in Minnesota. He is holding a pickaxe, a hoe, a pan, and two pistols. Note that he also has a bag labeled "gold" on his lap. What image do you think Northrup was trying to convey by posing in this way?

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Levi Strauss's Blue Jeans

One merchant who became rich during the gold rush was **Levi Strauss**. A Jewish German immigrant, he arrived in San Francisco in 1850. His goal was to manufacture tents and wagon covers for miners. But after noticing a demand for durable work pants, he began producing trousers made from the tent canvas he had purchased.

People loved the pants. Strauss sold enough to open a factory and started to produce the pants using a denim cloth known as *gênes* in French. Levi Strauss invented blue jeans and founded a company and a unique American brand.

THE FORTY-NINERS

By the following year, around 80,000 new gold-seekers had moved to California. They earned the nickname **forty-niners** because they arrived in 1849. The forty-niners came from all over the United States and the world. Consequently, the mining towns that sprang up to house and feed the forty-niners included diverse mixes of nationalities and cultures. Because slavery was not commonly practiced in California, many free African Americans decided to try their luck in the gold fields. Thousands of immigrants also arrived from China.

Most of the fortune-seekers were single men who hoped to find riches quickly and move on. Others headed to California with plans to settle there permanently. Whether they struck gold or not, many ended up staying. The boom in population created opportunities for all kinds of settlers. With a bit of creativity and business knowledge, people could make a fortune providing goods and services to the miners and other new residents of California.

However, the gold rush did not have a positive impact on everyone. Many people who had long lived in California found their livelihoods destroyed. **Californios**, or residents of Spanish or Mexican descent, had thrived on California's abundant farmland and prosperous ranchos. Newcomers to the area did not respect Californios' customs or legal rights, and in some cases they seized Californios' property. In addition, thousands of Native Americans died at the hands of gold miners or from the diseases that they and other settlers brought into the region.

California's population increased quite rapidly because of the gold rush. Before 1848, about 1,000 non-native people lived there. By the end of 1849, that number reached nearly 100,000. Even though most of the easily found gold deposits had been depleted by then, more fortune-seekers arrived each day. With that fast-growing population came a need for the laws and government that statehood could provide.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the California gold rush start?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** In what ways did the discovery of gold and the migration of the forty-niners affect Californios and others who had long lived in California?
3. **SUMMARIZE** How did the population of California change, and why?

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